In the two upper rooms of the women's ward, are put malefactors of either sex condemned to die, and sometimes pirates. I have here noted eighteen rooms: yet they are not sufficient for the number of prisoners. Mr. Hall is sometimes obliged to put men felons into some rooms of the women's ward. In so close a prison situated in a populous neighbourhood, I did not wonder frequently to find several felons sick on the floors. No bedding nor straw. The Act for preserving the health of prisoners and the clauses against spirituous liquors are hung up.

A chapel and two close rooms for the sick, lately built on the vacant ground where formerly was the house of correction; after the riots in 1780, were used for a bridewell till that in St. George's Fields was rebuilt. At my last visit the chapel was fitted up, and the two small rooms for an infirmary: these are on the ground-floor, only one window in each. Many were sick on the dirty floors; one of the turnkeys had lately died of a fever: of the fifty-five felons, etc., in October 1783, sixteen were fines, and I have the names and the sentences of twenty-five convicts, who are left languishing in this sickly gaol.[1]

Transports have not the king's allowance of 2s. 6d. a week. For these a merchant formerly contracted with the county to take them at the gaol: the gaoler sent them to the ship, attended by his servants; and received from the merchant 10s. 6d. for each prisoner so conducted.

Lent assize is at Kingston: summer assize at Guildford and Croydon [2] alternately.

There is hung up in the gaol a printed list of sixteen legacies and donations. The dates of the first six are 1555, 1571, 1576, 1584, 1597, 1598. Three are in the next century, viz. 1609, 1638, 1656. The other seven are not dated: and one of them noted on the list, has not been received since 1726. There are also other articles which seem to need inspection. Two of the charities are for debtors expressly: the others are not so distinguished; but debtors have them all. In the title of the paper it is said, "The gaol was formerly called the White Lion Prison." The common seal of the prison is a lion rampant. One of the legacies was bequeathed by Eleanor Gwynn, from which are sent to this prison once in eight weeks, sixty-five penny loaves. Common-side debtors have this as well as the preceding gifts.

Here I would just mention, that all the rags left by the felons after every assize, ought to be immediately burned, or rather buried; as they only serve to harbour vermin, dirt, and infection.

[1] The occasion of my visit at this time, to this and two or three other prisons, was, that I had seen on board the hulks a few days before, several sickly objects, who told me they had lately come from this and other gaols; which, by the looks of those convicts, I was persuaded must be in a bad state. I was sorry to find them confirm my suspicions, that our gaols are verging to their old state. Without much additional and unremitting care, the benefits produced of late years by attention to this object, will prove merely temporary.

[2] During the assize at Croydon the prisoners are confined in two stables at the "Three Tuns."

COUNTY BRIDEWELLS

ST. GEORGE'S FIELDS. At my late visits the prison was very dirty, and the prisoners still without employment.[1]

KINGSTON-UPON-THAMES. One of the prisoners who was committed for bastardy, not finding sureties, had been sent back hither, from the preceding quarter sessions at Reigate; where there is no prison. I had heard of the hardships suffered by prisoners when conveyed for trial to such towns; and inquired of this man, what was his situation at Reigate? He said that "He and fifteen others were confined there two or three days in a very small room; and almost suffocated." The keeper who was present confirmed the fact.

In 1782, I found the prison very dirty, and the prisoners still without employment. As the county allows no firing, bedding or bedsteads, many were lying sick on the floors. One woman was in a bed on the men's side and two women in the room for faulty apprentices, but they pay for this privilege. As I had been the preceding morning at Horsham Gaol, where proper humanity is shown even to felons, I was the more struck at seeing the wretched condition of these prisoners. There is a door from the men's court into that of the women's, and one of the men keeps the key, and can let any of the prisoners into the women's apartments. At my last visit, no alteration.

[1] If the great quantities of old cables and ropes piled up at the Tower were delivered out to the several keepers of bridewells in and about London to be wrought for use, and prompt payment made for the work, this would prevent the excuses of keepers for not employing their prisoners. See a similar mode in Holland, where the Admiralty and India Company find the old cords, and take the oakum when fit for use.